

CORE FORMULA

Behaviour + effect: "You did X, which helped Y." -> **Judgement + reason:** "That was a good call because X." -> **Expertise invitation:** "You would be the right person to ask about X." -> **Credit + specificity:** "That idea was yours, and it made the decision clearer." -> **Constraint empathy:** "You handled that with very little time and imperfect information."

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Spot one real contribution and name it specifically: "That was a good call because X."

BEST FOR

- Building rapport with capable, guarded or high-status people.
- Making colleagues, friends, dates or new contacts feel respected without overpraising.
- Leadership, coaching, supervision and team communication.
- Networking when you want to be warm without sounding transactional.
- Repairing subtle status tension after disagreement, correction or competition.
- Giving credit, appreciating invisible effort, and making other people look good.
- Encouraging someone to contribute more because their judgement is visibly valued.

PHRASE BANK

Quick credit · Short, everyday status signals

- "That was a good call."
- "You handled that well."
- "That made the decision clearer."
- "I liked how you approached that."
- "That was a useful way to frame it."
- "You saw the important part early."

Specific appreciation · Name the behaviour and its effect

- "The way you simplified that made it much easier to act on."
- "I appreciated how direct you were without making it harsh."
- "You asked the question everyone was avoiding."
- "That was a good example of restraint — you did not overcomplicate it."
- "You made a messy thing feel manageable."

Status-giving questions · Respect competence by asking

- "What would you look for here?"
- "You know this area well — what is your read?"
- "What would you do if you were judging this?"
- "What am I missing from your perspective?"
- "What is the part you would pay attention to first?"

Professional / leadership · Credit under pressure at work

- "I want to give you credit for that part of the solution."
- "Your read on the constraint was right."
- "You kept the group focused when it could have drifted."
- "That was a strong piece of judgement under pressure."
- "The value you added was making the trade-off visible."

Social / dating chemistry · Warmth in friendships and dates

- "That is very you, in a good way."
- "You are good at noticing the practical bit people miss."
- "That was a better call than I would have made."
- "I like that you actually thought that through."
- "You were calmer about that than most people would be."
- "I like how you think about that."
- "That is a good instinct."
- "You have good taste with that kind of thing."
- "That was a quietly confident move."
- "You are more observant than you let on."

Conflict / repair · Credit the valid point, then reset

- "The part I think you are right about is X."
- "I should give you credit for raising that concern early."
- "Even though I see the decision differently, I think your concern about X is fair."
- "You were protecting something important there."
- "That is a valid point, and I do not want to skip past it."
- "That sounded more flattering than I meant — I meant the specific point about X."
- "Let me say that less dramatically: your call on X helped."
- "I am not trying to overdo the praise. I just wanted to credit that part."
- "That came out a bit much. The simple version is: that was useful."
- "I do not want that to sound transactional — I genuinely appreciated X."

Digital / text · Credit that works in writing

- "That was a helpful catch — thanks."
- "Your summary made this easier to act on."
- "Good call on simplifying it."
- "Credit where it is due: that was your idea and it helped."
- "Appreciate the judgement here — it saved time."

High-status or guarded · Give input without fawning

- "That is the part I wanted your judgement on."
- "Your read on this would be useful because you have seen more versions of it."
- "I thought your point about X was the deciding factor."
- "That distinction was helpful."
- "I can see why people come to you for this."
- "That was helpful, by the way."
- "I liked that point you made earlier."
- "That was a useful way to see it."
- "You do not need to make a big thing of it, but that helped."
- "That was a good catch."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: "You are amazing."
Better: "That was useful."
Best: "The way you simplified that made the next step obvious."
2. Weak: "You are the smartest person here."
Better: "Good point."
Best: "Your point about timing changed how I am seeing the decision."

3. Weak: "Can you help me? You are so good at this."

Better: "Could I get your read?"

Best: "You have good judgement on this kind of issue. Could I get your read on one specific part?"

4. Weak: "You are totally right."

Better: "I see your point."

Best: "The part I think you are right about is the risk of moving too fast."

DECISION TREE

If They accept it warmly

Do not overdo it; continue naturally or ask a follow-up.

"Glad it helped. What would you look at next?"

If They deflect the praise

Shrink it and move on.

"Fair. Still, that point helped."

If They seem embarrassed

Drop the public attention; switch to brief, private credit.

"I will not make a thing of it, but that was a good catch."

If They seem suspicious of it

Remove any hint of strategy.

"No agenda — just giving credit where it is due."

If They start self-deprecating

Do not argue the praise; anchor it to the specific behaviour.

"Maybe, but that specific point was useful."

If You will need to make a request later

Separate the appreciation from the ask so it is not bait.

"Separate thing — I will come to the favour later."

SCENARIOS

A colleague spots a risk early

Credit the judgement and its effect, not the person in general. — "That was a useful catch — it probably saved us from finding it too late."

A quieter team member makes a good point

Bring the group's attention back to their contribution, by name. — "I want to come back to what Sam said, because that constraint is probably the key one."

You disagree but they raise a fair concern

Credit the valid part before you differ on the idea. — "I see it differently, but your concern about timing is fair."

Networking with someone whose expertise you value

Make them the expert and ask for their read. — "You have seen more versions of this than I have. What would you look for first?"

You want a high-status person's input without fawning

Credit one specific distinction they drew. — "Your distinction between X and Y was the useful part for me."

They send a genuinely useful answer by text

Name the effect their help had, briefly. — "That helped — your summary made the next step clearer."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- You do not genuinely mean it, or cannot make it specific.
- You are tempted to flatter because you want approval, access or reassurance.
- The person is uncomfortable with praise and needs privacy, brevity or a lighter touch.
- The moment requires direct accountability rather than reassurance.
- It would create an unfair status difference or embarrass someone publicly.

- You are using praise to soften them before a hidden ask.
- The compliment is about appearance, identity or sensitivity rather than a safe behaviour or contribution.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Notice the signal

Through the day, silently note every moment someone shows real judgement, effort, restraint or expertise. Say nothing yet — just train your eye for genuine status signals.

Day 2 — One specific signal

Once today, give a single specific status signal out loud: credit, effort-noticing, judgement appreciation, or a competence-respecting question. Keep it to one sentence.

Day 3 — Behaviour + effect

Rewrite three lazy compliments ("good job", "nice one", "you're great") into behaviour + effect, e.g. "Your summary made the decision clearer." Say the best one to a real person.

Day 4 — Restraint

Give one precise appreciation and then stop — no speech, no follow-on. Notice the urge to over-explain, and resist it.

Day 5 — Credit in a group

In one group setting, credit someone else by name for a point or contribution — especially a quieter person who might be overlooked.

Day 6 — Recover a miss

Deliberately let one bit of praise come out too big, then practise a recovery line: "That came out bigger than I meant — I just meant your call on X helped."

Day 7 — Separate credit from the ask

Where you need a favour, give the person genuine credit at a clearly separate time so it never functions as bait. Reflect: did it sound true, proportionate, and free of an agenda?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I give status because it was genuinely deserved, or because I wanted to be liked?
- Was it specific — a named behaviour and its effect — rather than vague flattery?
- Was it proportionate to what they actually did?
- Did I let the credit stand on its own, without attaching an ask?
- Did they seem respected, or managed?
- If it landed badly, did I shrink it and move on rather than forcing it?